

1930–1939

AUSTERE TIMES

The Wall Street Crash forced the frivolous bachelor girl of the 1920s to grow up and take life more seriously. The new silhouette was long and lean, emphasized by hemlines several centimetres below the knee, vertical seams, and slanting pockets. Perhaps in empathy with those actually on the breadline, anything round or full was abhorred, and women were all sharp angles and hipbones, their outlines sometimes softened by fur collars and cuffs. Linings or facings in contrasting colours, large pussy bows, belts, buttons, and deep cuffs were popular decorative features. Floral patterns were still fashionable for summer, while checks and plaids became particularly popular towards the end of the decade. Clutch bags, as slimline as their wearers, were held in hands sheathed in gloves with spiky gauntlets. Hair was worn close to the head in a permanent wave, at first still covered by close-fitting cloches and later adorned by a tiny hat worn at a jaunty angle.

Collar and cuffs Astrakhan (from a young lamb), fox, and other furs were often used for cuffs and, sometimes detachable, collars. Seams were used for decoration. Gloves and hats remained indispensable accessories for the fashionable woman.

1931

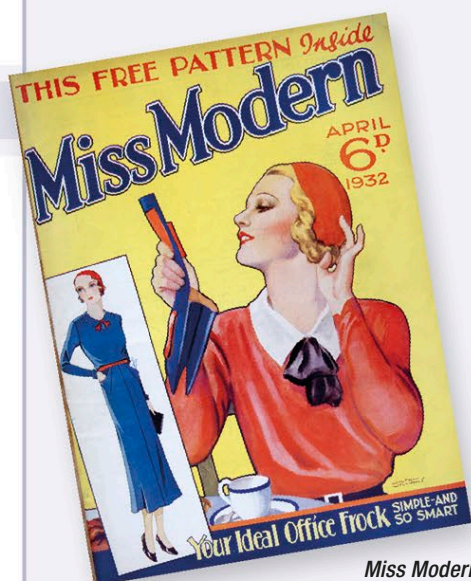
Fur shawl collar

Deep fur cuffs

Zigzag seaming

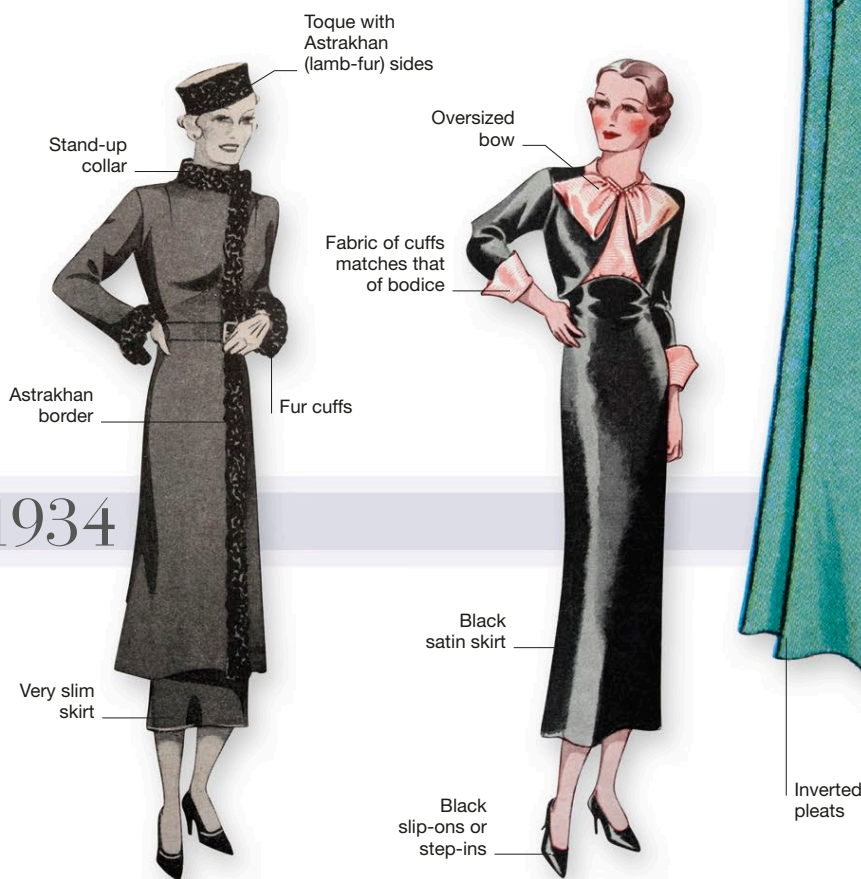
MISS MODERN

Aimed at the unmarried working girl, *Miss Modern* was a “sixpenny”, a cheap monthly British magazine first published in October 1930. Its ideal reader, shown here on the cover, was not afraid to check her make-up and adjust her hat in public using the mirror inside the flap of her fashionable clutch bag. The business girl could add to her smart wardrobe using the free pattern for an “ideal office frock” inside the magazine.



Miss Modern magazine cover

1934



Cossack coat In the winter of 1934 every smart woman was said to hanker after a Russian Cossack coat. Underneath, a blouse with cross-over fronts and a straight skirt were recommended.

Satin This “Sunday night” dress is constructed of a high-waisted skirt of black satin and a bodice of palest pink lamé. Gathered loops at the neck are made to look like a large bow.